anything in order to work for our future, because the international community will call Israel an apartheid country," he said.

Closer to home, Lapid joined the criticism of Breaking the Silence, accusing them of "undermining the foundations of the state" and supporting a bill to bar them from speaking in Israeli schools. (He spent his own military service working as a journalist for an army magazine.) He endorsed Miri Regev's attempt to cut state funding from the Midan Theater in Haifa, and described the BDS movement as a "puppet" in the hands of Hamas and Islamic Jihad. In late 2016, his party backed a right-wing bill to limit the involvement of NGOs in Israeli election campaigns, an idea cooked up in response to V15, the grassroots organization that tried to unseat Netanyahu the previous year. Perhaps the best example came in November, when he declined to participate in the annual memorial for the slain Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin. It was a leftist gathering, after all—Lapid would have to share the stage with Labor and Meretz.

The latest polls show Yesh Atid running neck-and-neck with Likud. They have limited utility so far away from the election, as President Jeb Bush can attest. Still, you can discern a few trends. The fragmentation in Israeli politics continues: both parties are polling around 25 seats, barely one-fifth of the Knesset. And crucially, most of Lapid's newfound support is stolen from Labor–trading within the center-left bloc, rather than expanding it. Even if he tried to join with Meretz, Labor, Kulanu and Yisrael Beiteinu, an unwieldy coalition covering the spectrum from the far left to the ultra-nationalist right, he would only have 57 seats, four short of a majority. (His aides also rule out Meretz as a partner, calling it "too ideological".)

So he has spent the past two years trying to woo the ultra-Orthodox, the perennial kingmakers of Israeli politics. He sits for long interviews on *haredi* radio stations. He never misses an opportunity to be photographed in a *kippah* at a religious event. On a visit to Eilat, he even seemed to drop his biggest priority: sharing the burden, he said, "will not be on the table if and when we form the next government." He later tried to "clarify" his statement after a furious reaction from his supporters, but the damage was done.

Lapid's efforts to find the "center" illustrate how Israel does not, in fact, have a coherent center, or even a simple left-right dichotomy. The trend over the past decade has been toward narrow parties, with charismatic leaders who focus on a core constituency. This worked for Lapid in 2013,